



When Trash Was Cash

As the mother of two young children in the early 1980s I was convinced I was saving money by using cloth diapers. But by the time baby number three was born in 1987, I'd discovered a reward to using disposables. Besides the obvious convenience, the manufacturers of several brands were offering generous coupons as well as on-package points and proofs that could be mailed in for free toys, coupons, cash, and even savings bonds. I started taking walks with my children on trash day just to collect the extra proofs of purchase. We'd roam the alleys together, stopping at each diaper box. I learned to swiftly tear the proof of purchase off in a stealth maneuver I'd refined with practice: pushing the stroller up close to the box, bending down as if tying my shoe, and ripping off the qualifier, all in less than thirty seconds. The kids were eager to help, picking up candy wrappers or carrying the grocery sack we toted with us everywhere. They knew that picking up trash resulted in more Christmas gifts or checks Mom could cash in at the grocery store for the special treat I bought them for behaving while I shopped. Not only that, but our walks sometimes netted immediate satisfaction in the form of books, magazines, rolls of wrapping paper, or even toys that had been discarded. My two oldest children collected pop cans for the cash deposit they'd spend at the local candy store. Occasionally